

Boston Sunday Globe

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OCTOBER 4, 2026

Texas blue? GOP’s grip hangs on one county

Democrats hope ‘perfect storm’ fuels Senate pick

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

FORT WORTH — The Tarrant County Democratic Party office is a shrine to great hopes past.

A custom wineglass for Wendy Davis, the pink sneaker-wearing filibustress who piqued Democratic optimism nationwide, but lost the governor’s race in 2014. An artistic rendering of Beto O’Rourke, the lanky, idealistic congressman who raised expectations even more, only to come up short for the Senate in 2018.

The only statewide winner on the wall: the legendary, coiffed Ann Richards — elected Texas governor in 1990.

Texas Democrats have been promising for more than a decade that they’ve got a candidate who can actually win this reliably red state. So far, each bid has ended in disappointment.

But this time is different, Texas Democrats say. Because 2026 is actually, finally, **TEXAS, Page A15**

AI has the voting booth surrounded

As a tool and a campaign issue, tech is unavoidable

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

The 2026 midterm campaign has featured a deluge of uncannily realistic images. Personalized digital assistants who confidently answer questions from voters within seconds. Powerful tools that dig up dirt on a candidate’s back-ground in a fraction of the time a human could.

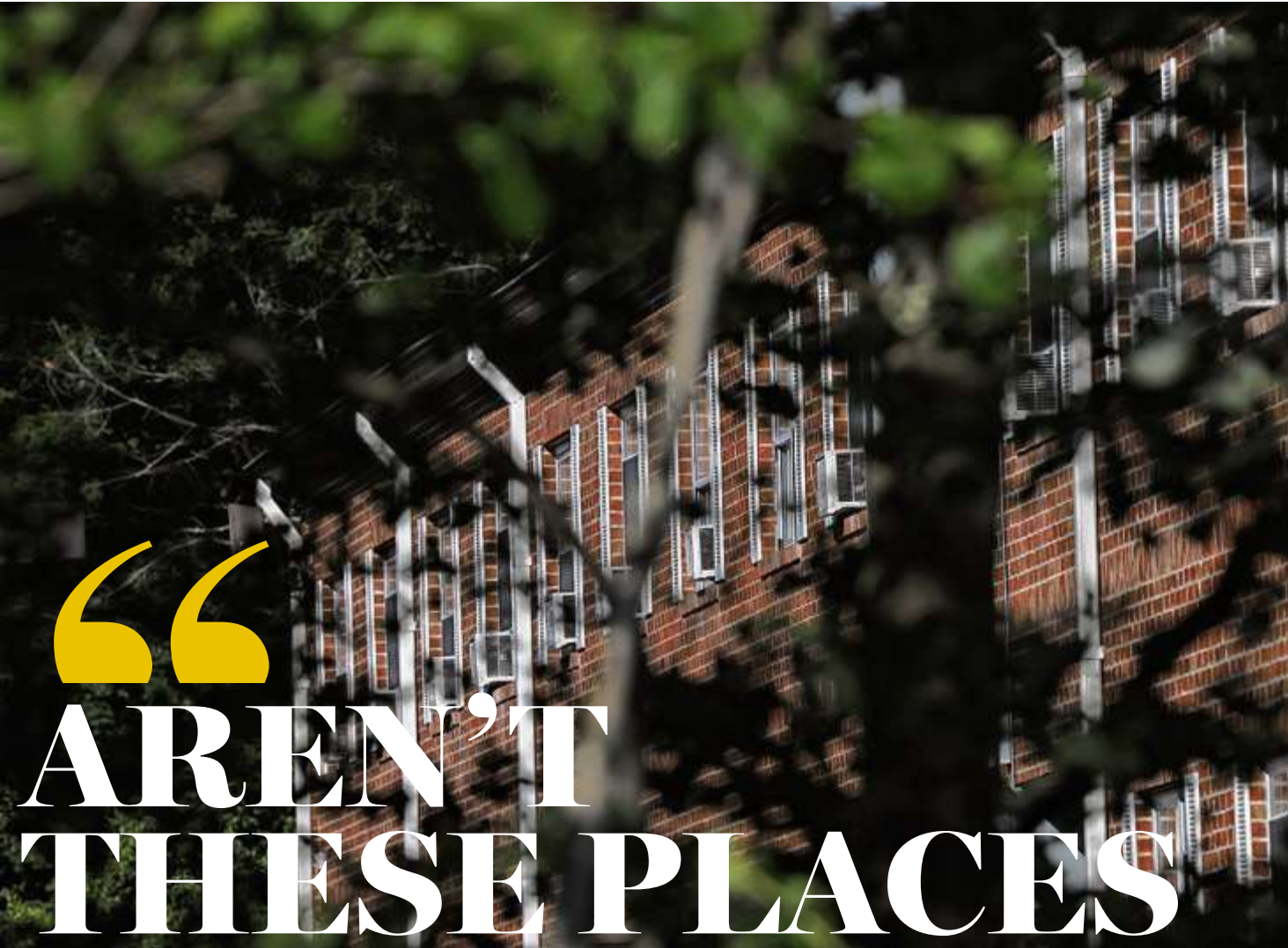
THE END OF NORMALCY Meanwhile, the balance of power in Washington, and in state capitals around the country, could hinge on how voters feel about the technology that has made these developments possible: artificial intelligence.

For the first time ever, Americans will vote in an election in which nearly every aspect of the democratic process has been touched by AI.

Pushed by long-shot candidates and powerful party groups alike, AI-generated images are now ubiquitous on social media feeds and TV screens, and are also blurring the line between political perception and reality in unprecedented ways.

Millions of voters are turning to AI chatbots **AI, Page A14**

Spotlight●



AREN’T THESE PLACES REGULATED?

He’s buying up nursing homes here, cutting spending and slashing care. Massachusetts regulators keep signing off.

By Kay Lazar, Neena Hagen, and Tricia L. Nadolny
GLOBE STAFF

The red-brick nursing home tucked off a busy road in Taunton used to be a rare jewel in a beleaguered industry, polished to a high sheen.

Floors gleamed from daily scrubbing. Residents’ clothes came back fresh and neatly folded. Employees stayed for decades. In early 2020, the 100-bed home earned the federal government’s highest quality rating — five stars — and held it for more than two years.

Then Eli Mirlis swept in from New Jersey and everything changed.

The Taunton purchase was one of many by Mirlis — so many that, over the past five years, he has become one of the largest nursing home operators in Massachusetts. During that stretch, his company, RegalCare, hacked at budgets so aggressively that basic supplies ran short, and veteran employees quit in frustration.

Beyond anything else, Mirlis went after the heart of any nursing home, cutting the hours of nursing staff at Taunton by nearly half, records show.

RegalCare’s corporate motto promised elderly and disabled residents they would “Rehab like Royalty.” But amid the squeeze, many experienced something far different: They pressed call buttons that went unanswered and sat in soiled diapers for hours. A transplant patient in Taunton was never given 40



doses of a medication to prevent organ rejection, according to federal records, and the hospital nurse who caught it couldn’t reach anyone at RegalCare for two weeks.

Within three years of Mirlis buying the Taunton home, federal regulators had knocked its coveted five-star quality rating down to one star, the lowest possible.

“We all worked very hard to get that building to a five-star,” said Joe Chaves, who ran maintenance and housekeeping in Taunton. He worked there 29 years, the last three under RegalCare’s ownership. “They came in, and it went out the window.”

The Boston Globe Spotlight Team found Mirlis fueled his breakneck ascent in Massachusetts with grim cuts to resident care while steering millions of dollars **NURSING HOMES, Page A4**

After Eli Mirlis (left) bought the former Longmeadow nursing home in Taunton (above) and added it to his RegalCare chain, its quality rating dropped.

SUZANNE KREITER/
GLOBE STAFF

A living room in Newton brings light to a lost master

John Leslie Breck in his Newton studio, circa 1895. The artist’s previously unmarked grave will receive a headstone later this month.



DWIGHT BLANEY PAPERS

By Malcolm Gay
GLOBE STAFF

For more than a century, one of Boston’s most important painters has lain in an unmarked grave at Forest Hills Cemetery, his name all but erased from the annals of art history.

During his brief life, John Leslie Breck won widespread acclaim as a founder of American Impressionism. He painted side-by-side with Claude Mon-

et and is said to have been romantically entangled with one of the artist’s stepdaughters.

But in 1899, at just 38 years old, Breck died under mysterious circumstances at a private club in the Back Bay. His legacy quickly faded from public view, his paintings hidden away and his remains all but forgotten in an anonymous plot.

He might have remained that way, too, were it not for an **BRECK, Page A16**

Plane missing off Nantucket

A search was underway for a medical flight carrying six people that reported problems after leaving Bermuda. **B1.**

Twenty percent of public school students in Massachusetts need an IEP. We spoke with experts about getting the most from the process. **Globe Magazine.**

Sol-less

Sunday: Cloudy, little sun. High: 61-66. Low: 54-59.

Monday: Breezy, warmer.

Complete report, **A24.**

Deaths, **A18-23.**

VOL. 310, NO. 96

Suggested retail price
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